

Realme 16 Pro

A good phone let down by its price

With the Realme 16 Pro, Realme has made an unexpected and somewhat confusing shift in its mid-range lineup. Instead of continuing with the Snapdragon chipset used in the Realme 15 Pro, the company has moved to the MediaTek Dimensity 7300 Max. It is a change that immediately sets the tone for what this phone is trying to be, especially since much of the rest of the hardware remains familiar, and in some cases, almost unchanged. Priced starting at Rs 31,999, the Realme 16 Pro positions itself in a highly competitive part of the market where expectations around performance, cameras and long-term value are naturally higher. This is also where the phone starts raising questions.

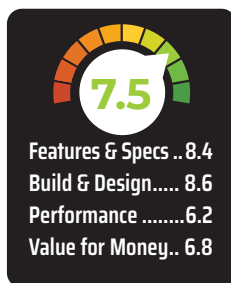
After using the Realme 16 Pro as a daily device for a while, the real question is not whether it is a good phone, but whether it justifies its asking price.

DESIGN AND BUILD

For the first time in the number series, Realme has collaborated with Naoto Fukasawa, and the overall aesthetic reflects that. The phone looks clean and measured rather than expressive. The camera module, however, feels familiar, borrowing cues from recent flagship designs rather than attempting something truly distinctive. This is not necessarily a flaw, but it means the phone blends in rather than standing out.

The Pulse Light found on the earlier Realme 15 Pro has been removed, and its absence does not feel like a compromise. The review unit I received came in Orchid Purple, a colour that avoids being loud or overly reflective. It looks

₹31,999



restrained and practical, which suits the overall design direction.

The back panel is plastic, but the build feels solid enough. The power and volume buttons are tactile and responsive. Front bezels are slim, contributing to a modern look, though the phone is large. One-handed use is not particularly comfortable. That said, the phone does not feel very heavy, which is notable given the battery capacity.

Durability is one area where Realme clearly pushes harder than most competitors. The Realme 16 Pro carries IP66, IP68, IP69 and IP69K certifications, offering protection against dust, full water immersion and even high-pressure water jets.

The phone includes stereo speakers that can be pushed to a 300% volume level. At maximum output, clarity drops, but loudness is not an issue. An

IR blaster is also present, allowing the phone to control compatible household appliances. The fingerprint scanner works reliably, though its placement sits slightly lower on the display than ideal.

DISPLAY

The Realme 16 Pro features a 6.78-inch 1.5K AMOLED panel with a 144Hz refresh rate. In daily use, the display feels fluid and responsive, particularly during scrolling and browsing. Motion handling remains smooth, and the high refresh rate is consistently maintained.

I tested the device in Vibrant colour mode. In this setting, colours appear punchy without looking artificially boosted, and viewing angles remain stable. Long viewing sessions, including streaming content, do not reveal obvious shortcomings.

In display testing, the panel recorded an average Delta E of 1.7 in Calman colour testing, with 96% colour gamut coverage. These figures are acceptable for the segment, though they do not quite match class-leading panels that prioritise accuracy over saturation.

Realme claims a peak brightness of 6,500 nits and 1,400 nits in high-brightness mode. In testing, the panel reached approximately 2,620 nits. This is more than sufficient for outdoor visibility and ensures comfortable use even under direct sunlight.

PERFORMANCE

The Realme 16 Pro is powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 7300 Max SoC. Despite the updated naming, this chipset is functionally the same as the Dimensity 7300 Plus used in the Realme 15 5G. More importantly, it represents a downgrade from the Snapdragon 7 Gen 4 found in the Realme 15 Pro, despite the price being unchanged.

The review unit came equipped with 12 GB of RAM and 256 GB of internal storage. Day-to-day, the phone performs reliably. App launches are quick,